



Chess for Kids

Learn to Play, Step by Step

A printable guide — from your very first move to your first checkmate.

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Welcome, Future Chess Champion! ♔

A friendly guide for first-time players — read it on your own or with a grown-up.

What is chess?

Chess is a game for **two players**. Think of it like a friendly battle between two little armies — a **white** army and a **black** army.

Each army has a **King** who must be kept safe, a powerful **Queen**, and lots of helpers: tall **Rooks**, sneaky **Bishops**, jumping **Knights**, and brave little **Pawns**.

Your big goal is to trap the **other** king so he cannot escape. When you do that, you win! That trap has a special name: **checkmate**.



The one-sentence rule of chess: Move your pieces to trap the enemy king — while keeping your own king safe.

How to use this guide

Go in order using the menu on the left, like steps on a ladder. Each page teaches just one small new thing, so it never feels too hard.

Along the way you'll see little colored boxes. Here's what they mean:



Tip — a smart idea to help you play better.



Watch out — a common mistake to avoid.



Remember — something important to keep in your head.



COACH NOTE

Extra detail and the "real" chess words — great for older kids and the grown-up reading along. Little kids can skip these and come back later.

What you'll be able to do at the end

- Set up the board the right way ♖
- Move every single piece correctly
- Say "check!" and deliver a checkmate
- Do the cool special moves (castling, promotion, en passant)
- Read and write chess moves like the pros
- Use clever tricks called **tactics** to win pieces
- Play a whole game from start to finish — with good manners!

Ready? Let's meet the board! →

The Board & Setting Up

Before the battle starts, everyone lines up in the right spot.

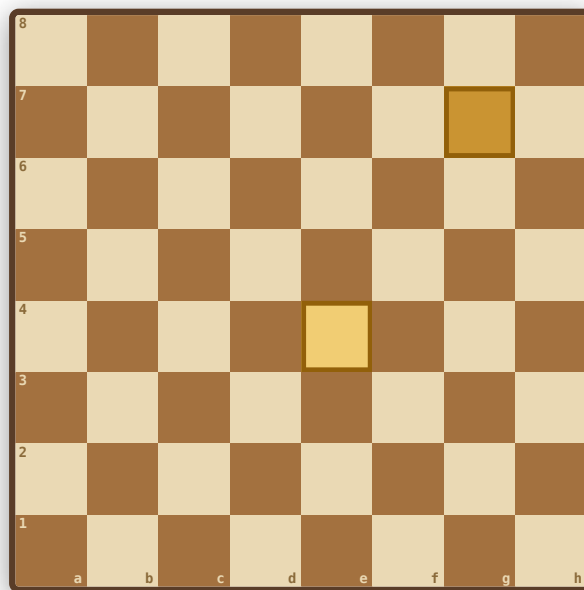
The battlefield: 64 squares

A chessboard is a big square made of **64 small squares** — 8 across and 8 down. The squares take turns being **light** and **dark**, like a checkerboard.

The board has two kinds of lines:

- **Files** — the columns that *go up and down*. We name them with letters **a** to **h**.
- **Ranks** — the rows that *go left and right*. We name them with numbers **1** to **8**.

Every square has its own name made of a letter and a number, like **e4** or **g7**. (Look at the small letters and numbers on the edge of the board below!)



The two yellow squares are **e4** (letter e, row 4) and **g7** (letter g, row 7).

🧩 Square names are like seats in a movie theater: a letter for the column, a number for the row. **e4** means "go to column e, row 4."

Two golden setup rules

★ **Rule 1: "Light on the right."** When you sit down, the square in your bottom-right corner should be a *light* square. If it's dark, turn the board around!

★ **Rule 2: "The queen loves her own color."** The white queen starts on a light square, and the black queen starts on a dark square. (The kings stand right next to their queens.)

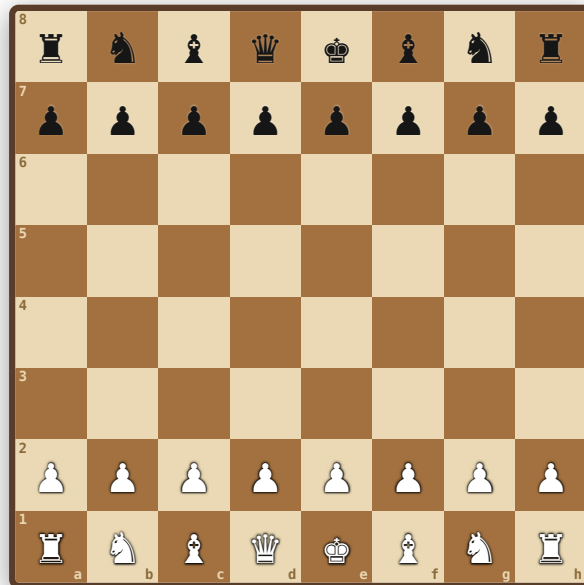
👑 COACH NOTE

An easy way to remember Rule 2: "**Queen on her own color.**" If your queen is sitting on the wrong color at the start, the kings and queens are swapped — fix it before you begin.

Where everyone stands

The pieces line up on the two rows closest to each player. The **pawns** stand in front like a wall of soldiers. Behind them stand the bigger pieces.

From the corners going in, the back row goes: **Rook, Knight, Bishop, Queen, King, Bishop, Knight, Rook.**



The starting position. White is at the bottom and always moves first.

✅ **Memory trick:** The big towers (Rooks) guard the corners. Knights stand next to them. Bishops next. And in the middle, the King and Queen sit together like royalty.

🕒 **Who goes first?** White always makes the first move. Then players take turns — white, black, white, black — one move each turn.

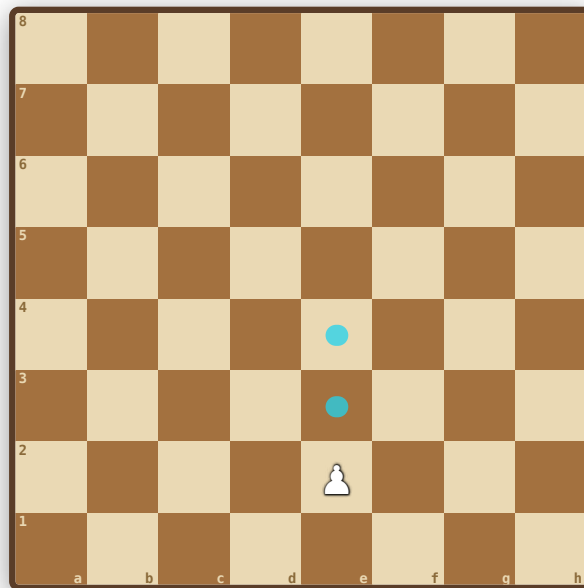
The Pawn ♙

Small and brave — the little soldier who only marches forward.

How the pawn moves

A pawn is the smallest piece, but don't laugh at it! Pawns are brave little soldiers who march straight ahead and never go backward.

- A pawn moves **one square straight forward**.
- **Special first move:** the very first time a pawn moves, it may jump **two** squares forward instead of one — like an excited sprint at the start!

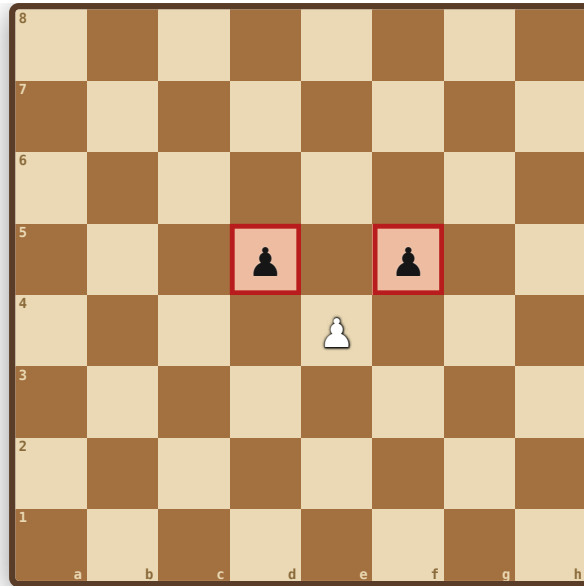


*This pawn hasn't moved yet, so it can step to **e3** or sprint to **e4** (the blue dots).*

⚠ Watch out: A pawn can never move backward or sideways. Once it marches forward, there's no turning back!

How the pawn captures (this is the tricky part!)

Here's the funny thing about pawns: they move straight, but they **capture diagonally** — one square forward to the left, or one square forward to the right.



The white pawn on **e4** can capture either black pawn on the red squares (**d5** or **f5**) — but it can't capture straight ahead.

★ **Remember:** Pawns walk straight but punch sideways (diagonally). If an enemy stands *directly in front* of a pawn, the pawn is stuck and cannot capture it.

The pawn's amazing superpower: Promotion

If a pawn is brave enough to march *all the way* to the far end of the board, something magical happens. It gets **promoted** — you turn it into a much stronger piece, almost always a **Queen**!

👑 A tiny pawn that reaches the other side becomes a mighty queen. You can even have *two* queens this way! (We'll practice this in **Special Moves**.)

👑 COACH NOTE

A promoting pawn can become a **queen, rook, bishop, or knight** — your choice. 99% of the time you pick the queen because it's strongest. The rare times a knight is better are called "underpromotion."

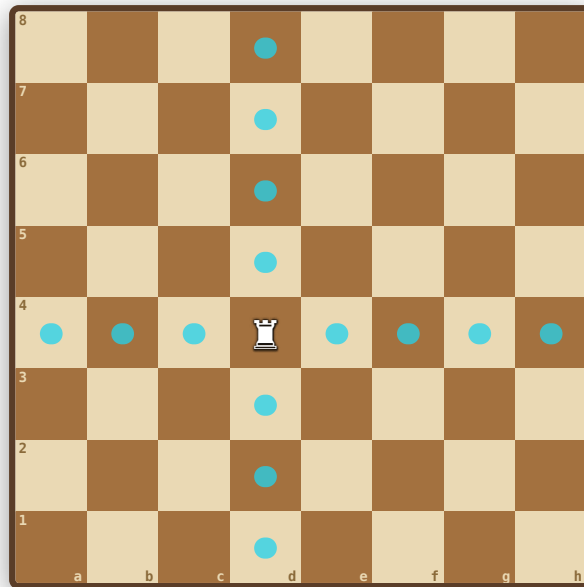
The Rook ♖

The tall castle tower that rolls in straight lines.

How the rook moves

The rook looks like a little castle tower. It moves in **straight lines** — up, down, left, or right — as far as you like, as long as nothing is in the way.

Think of it like a train on tracks: it can go a long, long way, but only straight, never diagonally.



*The rook on **d4** can slide to any blue dot — all along its row and its column.*

✅ **Rooks love open lines.** A rook is happiest when there's a long empty row or column in front of it — it can zoom across the whole board.

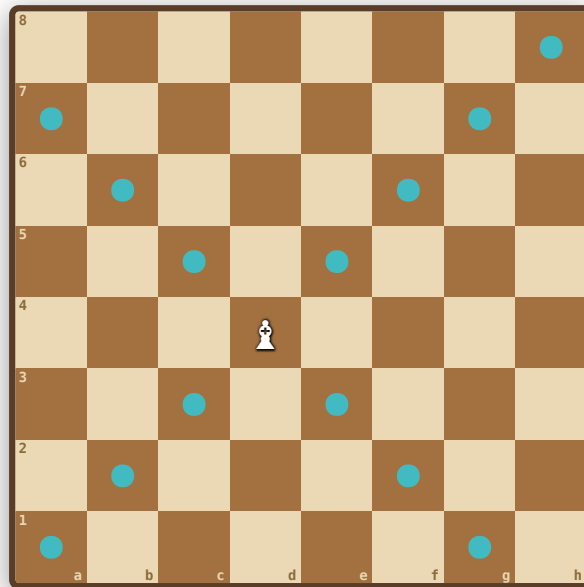
⚠️ A rook cannot jump over pieces. If a friend or enemy is in the way, the rook must stop. (It *can* capture an enemy that's blocking it!)

The Bishop ♖

The diagonal slider that lives on one color forever.

How the bishop moves

The bishop moves in **diagonal lines** — like sliding on ice corner-to-corner. It can go as far as it wants, as long as the path is clear.



The bishop on d4 zooms along both diagonals (the blue dots).

★ **A funny rule:** A bishop that starts on a light square stays on light squares for the *whole game*. It can never reach a dark square! Each army has one "light-squared" bishop and one "dark-squared" bishop.

👤 COACH NOTE

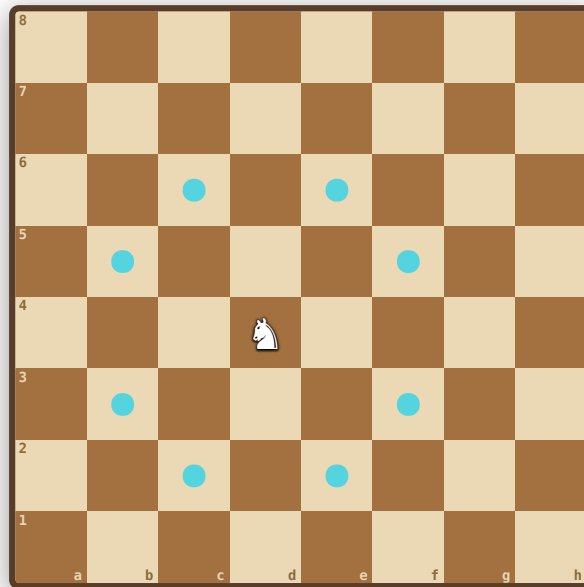
Because the two bishops cover different colors, they make a great team — together they can reach *every* square. Having both bishops is called the "**bishop pair**," and it's a small but real advantage.

The Knight 🐎

The jumping horse that moves in an L — the trickiest piece of all!

How the knight moves

The knight is the funny one. It doesn't slide in a line at all. It hops in the shape of the letter "L": **two squares one way, then one square to the side.**



*The knight on **d4** can jump to any of the 8 blue dots — each one is an "L" away.*

🐎 **The knight's superpower: it can JUMP!** It's the only piece that hops right over other pieces — friends or enemies. Nothing can block a knight.

★ **Color trick:** A knight always lands on the *opposite* color from where it started. Light square → dark square → light square, every single hop.

👑 COACH NOTE

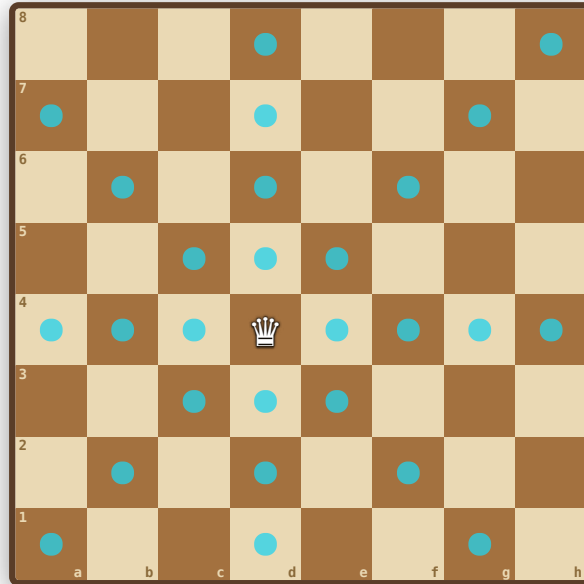
Knights are strongest in the **middle** of the board (up to 8 jumps) and weakest in the corner (only 2 jumps). There's an old chess saying: "**A knight on the rim is dim.**" Keep your knights near the center!

The Queen ♔

The superhero of the army — your most powerful piece.

How the queen moves

The queen is the strongest piece on the board. Why? Because she moves like a **rook AND a bishop combined** — straight lines *and* diagonals, as far as she wants!



*Look how many squares the queen controls from **d4** ! She's a true superhero.*

⚠ **Watch out:** Because the queen is so precious, don't rush her into battle too early. If she gets chased around or captured, you'll be very sad. Protect your queen!

👑 COACH NOTE

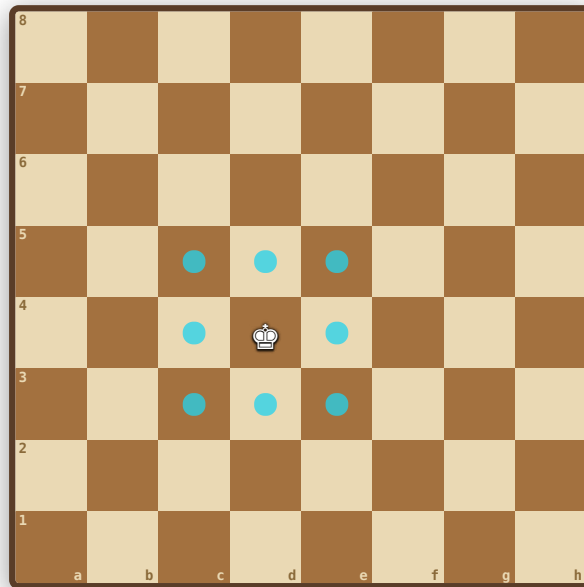
The queen is worth about **9 points** (more on values later). Losing her for nothing usually loses the game. Bring her out only *after* your smaller pieces are developed.

The King

The most important piece — slow, but you must protect him at all costs.

How the king moves

The king is the **most important** piece — if he gets trapped, the game is over. But he's also slow: he can only move **one square at a time**, in any direction (straight or diagonal), like a careful grandpa taking small steps.



*The king on **d4** can step to any of the 8 squares around him — just one square per turn.*

 **The most important rule in chess:** You can never let your king be captured. And a king can *never* move onto a square where an enemy could capture him. He must always stay safe.

 **Kings can't touch!** The two kings can never stand right next to each other — they must always have at least one square between them.

 **Keep your king cozy.** In the early game, tuck your king safely in a corner (we'll learn the special "castling" move for that). A king out in the open is in big danger.

Capturing & Taking Turns

How to win pieces from the other army.

Taking turns

Chess is polite: players take turns, **one move each**. White moves, then black moves, then white again, and so on. You can't skip your turn, and you can't move twice.

 You *must* make a move on your turn — even if you don't want to. There's no "passing" in chess.

How capturing works

To **capture** means to take an enemy piece off the board. You do it by moving your piece *onto* the square where the enemy piece is standing. Your piece takes its place, and the enemy piece is gone for good.

1 Move the way your piece is allowed to move

A rook captures along straight lines, a bishop along diagonals, and so on. Capturing follows the same movement rules.

2 Land on the enemy's square

Lift the enemy piece off the board and put your piece there instead.

 You **never have to capture** (except to save your king). Capturing is a choice. Sometimes it's smart, sometimes it's a trap!

 **Remember the pawn is different:** it captures *diagonally*, not straight ahead. Every other piece captures the same way it moves.

"Is it protected?" — the most useful question

Before you capture something, ask: "**If I take that piece, can the enemy take me back?**" A piece that a friend is guarding is called **protected** (or defended).

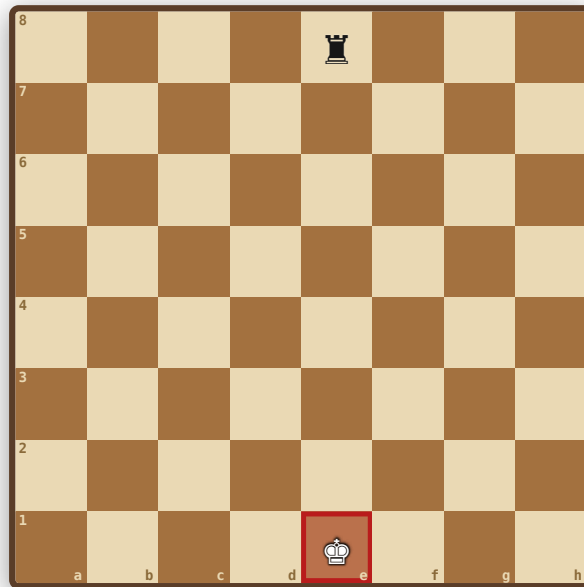
 Trading a small piece to win a big one is great. Trading a big piece to win a small one is usually a mistake. We'll learn exactly how much each piece is worth in the **What Pieces Are Worth** page.

Check & Checkmate

This is how you actually win the game!

Check = the king is in danger

When a piece is attacking the enemy king — meaning it *could* capture the king next turn — we say the king is in **check**. It's like shouting "Watch out!" to warn the king.



*The black rook attacks straight down the column at the white king. The king is in **check**!*

🚩 **When you're in check, you MUST get out of it right away.** You can't ignore it and do something else.

Three ways to escape check



Move the king to a safe square



Block — put a piece in the way



Capture the attacking piece

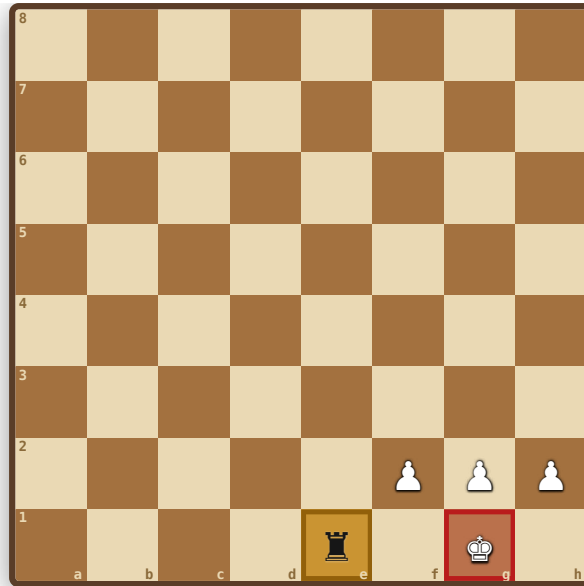
★ If you can do *any* one of these three things, you're safe and the game continues.

👑 COACH NOTE

Two exceptions for older players: you **can't block** a check from a knight (it jumps, so there's nothing to block) or a piece right next to the king. And in a **double check** (two pieces checking at once), blocking and capturing don't help — the king *must* move.

Checkmate = the king is trapped — YOU WIN! 🏆

If the king is in check and there is **no way to escape** — can't move, can't block, can't capture — then it's **checkmate**. The game is over and the player who gave checkmate **wins**!



*The black rook checks the white king. The king can't escape — his own pawns block him in. This is **checkmate**!*

✅ This famous pattern is called the "**back-rank mate**." The king got trapped on the edge by his own pawns. (Tip: make a little escape hole for your king so this can't happen to you!)

📖 **COACH NOTE**

The word "checkmate" comes from an old phrase meaning "**the king is helpless**." Notice: in checkmate, nobody actually captures the king — the game ends the instant escape becomes impossible. The whole game is one long race to checkmate the other king first.

Basic Checkmates

You know what checkmate is — now here's how to actually deliver it.

The two-rook ladder — the easiest mate to learn

Two rooks can checkmate a lonely king all by themselves — you don't even need your own king to help! Because it's so simple, this is the first checkmate every young player should learn. It works like climbing a **staircase**.

1 Build a wall

Put one rook on a row right next to the enemy king. Now the king can't cross that line toward you.

2 Push with the other rook

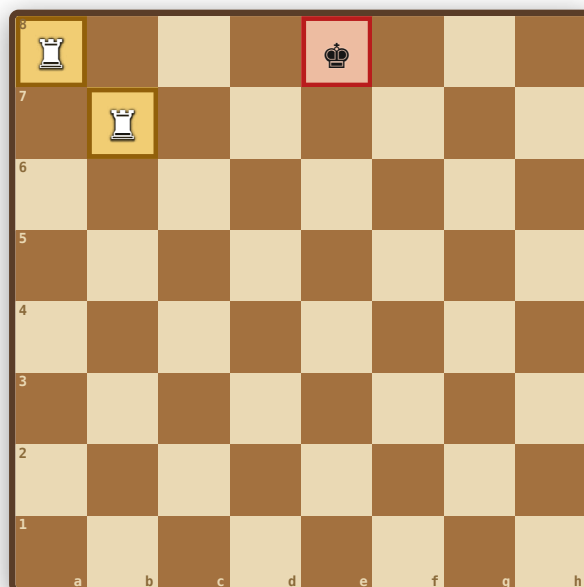
Use your second rook to give **check** on the king's own row. The king has to step back one row.

3 Climb the staircase

Move your first rook up to the next row and check again. Step by step, the two rooks walk the king to the edge of the board.

4 Checkmate on the edge

One rook checks the king on the very last row; the other guards the row right next to it, so there's nowhere to run.

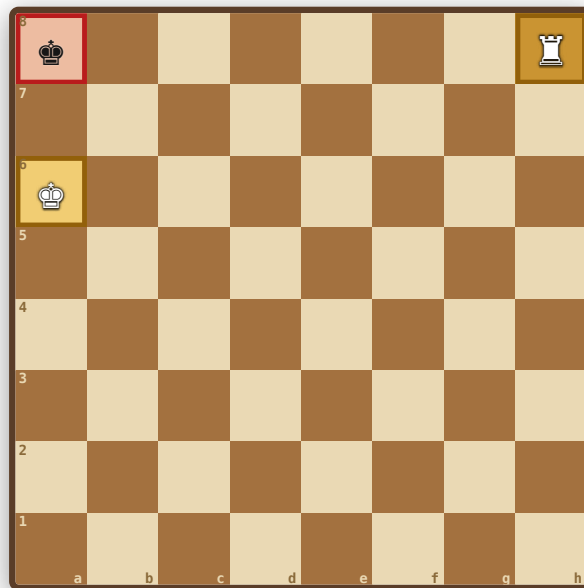


The finish: one rook checks along the back row, the other seals the row below. The king is trapped — checkmate!

✓ **If the king runs at one of your rooks, don't panic** — just slide that rook far away along its row (stay on the same line!) and keep laddering.

King + Rook mate

With only *one* rook, your king has to help. The two kings stand face-to-face with one square between them, and the rook delivers the check from the side. The enemy king can't step forward (your king guards those squares) and can't step back (it's already on the edge).



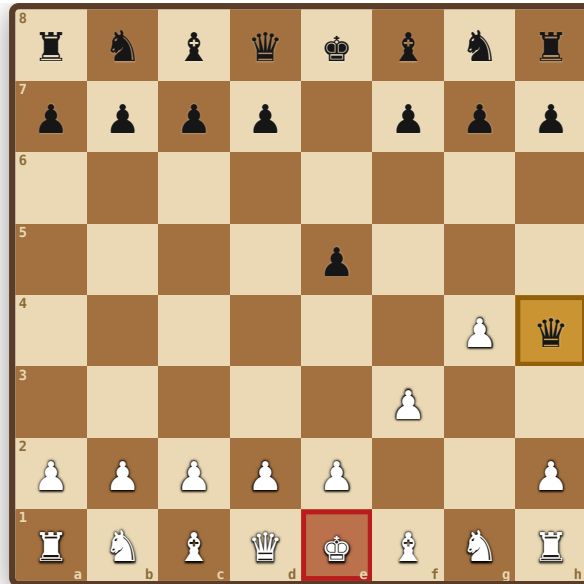
The rook checks along the top row; the white king covers the escape squares below. Checkmate!

⚠ This one is trickier than two rooks — it takes practice to walk the enemy king to the edge. Keep your king close to help, and watch out for stalemate.

Two famous fast mates (just for fun!)

Fool's Mate — the fastest checkmate of all

Believe it or not, a game can end in just **two moves**! It only happens if a player makes two terrible opening moves and opens the door to their own king: `1. f3 e5 2. g4?? Qh4#`.

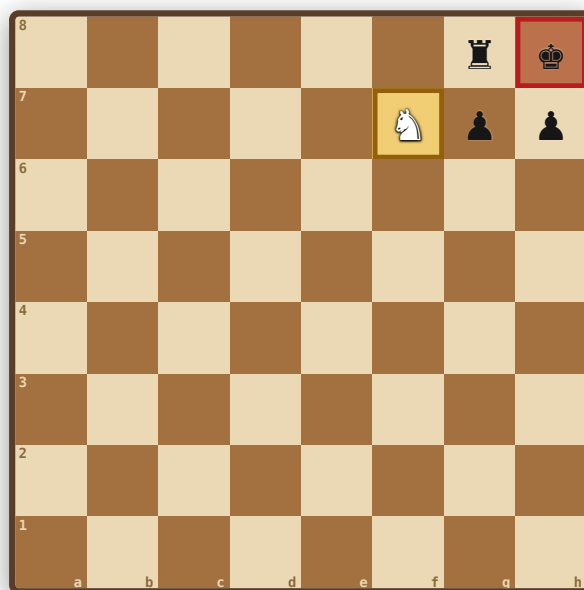


The black queen swoops to h4. The white king has no escape and nothing can block. Mate in two moves!

★ You'll almost never see this in a real game — but it shows why you shouldn't weaken the squares right around your own king.

Smothered Mate — trapped by your own team

A **smothered mate** is when a knight checkmates a king that is boxed in by its *own* pieces. The king has nowhere to go because his own friends block every escape square — and only the jumping knight can reach him!



The knight checks the king in the corner. His own rook and pawns block every escape. Checkmate!

👑 COACH NOTE

Smothered mate often arrives after a dazzling **queen sacrifice** called *Philidor's Legacy*: the queen gives itself up with **Qg8+!!**, the rook is forced to take (**Rxg8**), and then **Nf7#** snaps shut. One of the prettiest patterns in chess — worth showing the older kid.

Stalemate & Draws

Sometimes nobody wins — the game is a tie.

What is a draw?

A **draw** means the game ends in a **tie** — nobody wins, nobody loses. It happens more than you'd think! There are a few ways a game can be a draw.

Stalemate (the sneaky tie)

Stalemate is the trickiest one. It happens when a player is **NOT in check**, but has **no legal move** at all — every move would be against the rules. When that happens, the game is a draw instead of a win.

⚠️ **Super important when you're winning!** If you have lots of pieces and the enemy has only a king, be careful not to accidentally stalemate them. You'd throw away your win and only get a tie! Always leave the lonely king at least one safe square — until you're ready to checkmate.

👮 COACH NOTE

The difference is simple: **checkmate** = king is in check AND has no escape (you win). **Stalemate** = king is NOT in check BUT has no legal move (it's a draw). One letter of difference in the result — a whole win thrown away. Beginners lose half-points to stalemate all the time, so slow down when finishing.

Other ways to draw

Type of draw	What it means
Agreement	Both players simply agree to call it a tie.
Not enough pieces	Neither side has enough material to checkmate (for example, just two lonely kings).
Repetition	The exact same position happens three times — the game goes in circles.
50-move rule	If 50 moves pass with no capture and no pawn move, it's a draw.

✅ A draw isn't a loss! If you're playing someone stronger, holding a draw can feel like a victory.

Special Moves

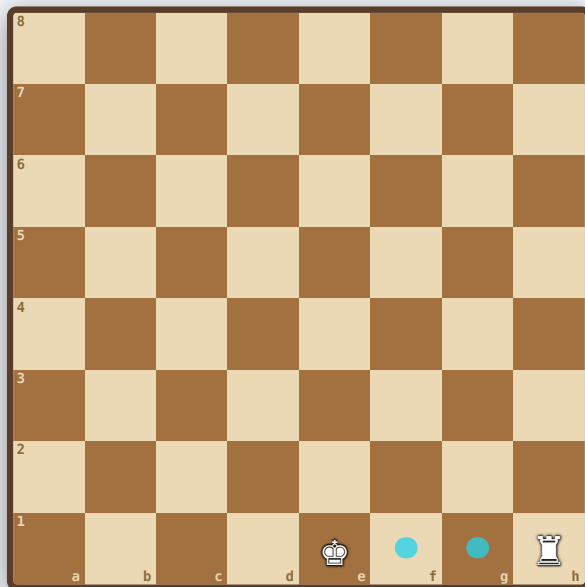
Three cool moves that surprise beginners — learn them and feel like a pro!

1. Castling — hide your king ♔

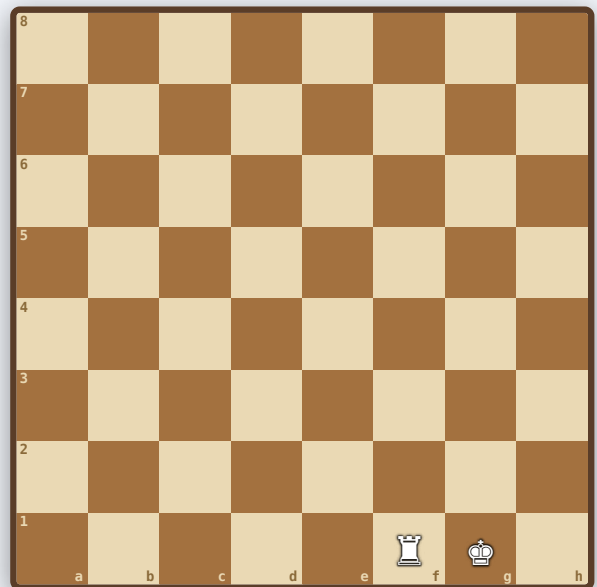
Castling is a special move where the **king and a rook move at the same time**. It's the only time you ever move two of your own pieces in one turn. It does two great things at once: it tucks your king safely into the corner *and* brings a rook toward the action.

The king slides **two squares** toward a rook, and the rook hops over to the king's other side.

Before castling



After castling



The king moved from **e1** to **g1**, and the rook jumped from **h1** to **f1**. Safe and snug!

You can only castle if...

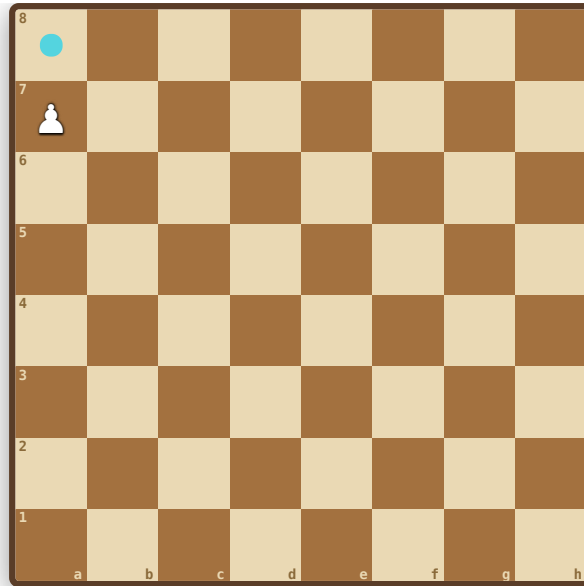
- Your king and that rook have **never moved** yet.
- There are **no pieces between** them.
- Your king is **not in check**, and doesn't pass through or land on a square the enemy attacks.

👩 COACH NOTE

Castling toward the near rook (the **h** -file) is **kingside** castling, written **0-0**. Toward the far rook (the **a** -file) is **queenside** castling, written **0-0-0**. Castling early (usually kingside) is one of the best beginner habits — a safe king wins more games.

2. Promotion — pawn becomes a queen ♚

Remember the pawn's superpower? When a pawn marches all the way to the far end, it gets **promoted** — you swap it for a queen (or rook, bishop, or knight, but almost always a queen).



One more step to **a8** — and this little pawn becomes a powerful queen!

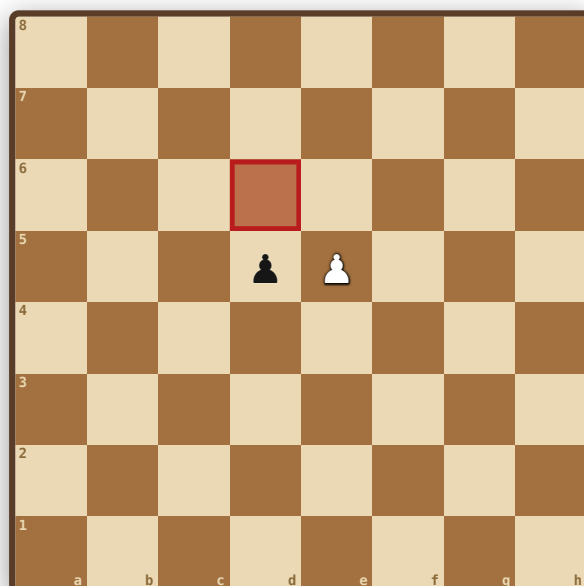


This is why even a single extra pawn matters — it might grow up into a brand-new queen and win the game.

3. En passant — the surprise pawn capture

This one has a fancy French name (say it "on-pass-ON"). It means "**in passing**." It's a special way one pawn can capture another.

If an enemy pawn uses its big two-square first move to zoom *right past* your pawn — landing beside it — you're allowed to capture it as if it had only moved one square. But you must do it **immediately**, on the very next move, or you lose the chance!



The black pawn just sprinted from **d7** to **d5**, sliding past the white pawn. White may capture "en passant" by moving to the red square **d6** — and the black pawn is removed.

⚠ En passant is the most-forgotten rule in chess! Don't worry if it feels strange — even grown-ups forget it. Just remember: it only works *right away*, and only against a pawn's two-square sprint.

Reading & Writing Moves

The secret code chess players use to write down their games.

Why learn the code?

Chess has its own little writing system called **notation**. Once you know it, you can read chess books, follow famous games, and write down your own moves to look at later. It's like learning a secret language — and it's easier than it looks!

Each piece has a letter

Piece	Letter	Why
♔ King	K	K for King
♚ Queen	Q	Q for Queen
♖ Rook	R	R for Rook
♗ Bishop	B	B for Bishop
♘ Knight	N	N (because K is taken by the King!)
♙ Pawn	(no letter)	Pawns are so common they don't need one

★ The sneaky one: a **knight is N**, not K. The King already grabbed the letter K!

How to write a move

To write a move, put the piece's letter and then the square it moves to.

PIECE	SQUARE
N Knight	f3 where it goes

Nf3 means "Knight goes to f3."

For a pawn, just write the square: e4 means "the pawn moves to e4." Easy!

Special symbols

Symbol	Means	Example
x	capture (takes a piece)	Bxf7 = bishop takes on f7
+	check	Qh5+ = queen to h5, check!
#	checkmate (you win!)	Qxf7# = checkmate!
0–0	castle kingside	short castle

0-0-0

castle queenside

long castle

=Q

promote to queen

e8=Q = pawn becomes a queen

✅ **Try reading this:** e4 e5 Nf3 means: white pawn to e4, black pawn to e5, white knight to f3. You just read your first chess moves!

👤 **COACH NOTE**

This is called **algebraic notation** — the standard worldwide. Sometimes two of the same piece can reach a square, so we add the starting file or rank to be clear (e.g. Nbd2 = the knight from the b-file goes to d2). Writing down your games lets you review them afterward — the #1 way to improve fast.

What Each Piece Is Worth

Knowing the points helps you make smart trades.

The point values

Pieces aren't all equal. We give each one a number of **points** to show how valuable it is. This helps you decide whether a trade is good or bad. (The points are just for thinking — you don't actually score them.)

Piece	Points	Think of it as...
♙ Pawn	1	a brave little helper
♘ Knight	3	a tricky jumper
♗ Bishop	3	a long-range slider
♖ Rook	5	a powerful tower
♕ Queen	9	the superhero
♔ King	∞ (priceless)	you can never lose him!

★ Easy way to remember: **pawn 1, knight and bishop 3, rook 5, queen 9**. The king has no number because losing him means losing the game.

Making smart trades

When you think about capturing, compare the points. Winning *more* points than you give up is a good trade.

✔ GOOD: Give a knight (3) to win a rook (5). You gained 2 points!

✖ BAD: Give your queen (9) to win a pawn (1). You lost 8 points!

✔ Knights and bishops are both worth 3, so trading one for the other is usually fair — it depends on the position.

👑 COACH NOTE

Having more total points than your opponent is called being "**up material**." A common goal: win material safely, trade pieces to simplify, then turn your extra power into a winning attack or a new queen. Just remember points are a guide, not a law — a well-placed knight can be worth more than a sleepy rook.

Tricks & Tactics

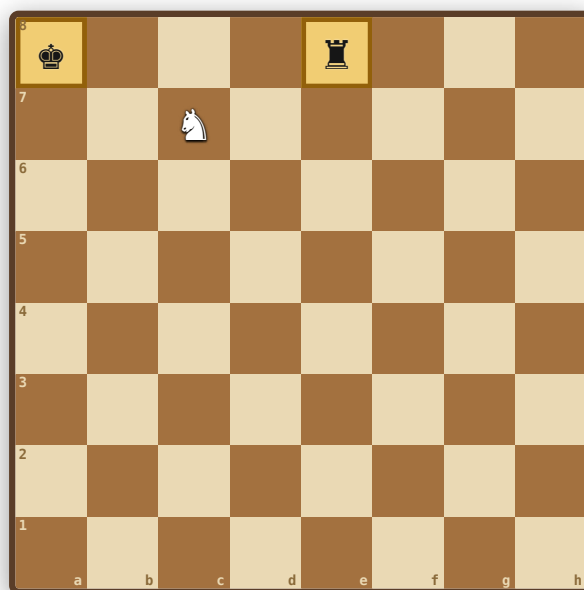
Clever short combos that win pieces — the fun part of chess!

What's a tactic?

A **tactic** is a short, clever trick that wins a piece or delivers checkmate. Spotting tactics is the fastest way to start beating opponents. Here are the three most important ones to learn first.

The Fork — attack two things at once! 🍴

A **fork** is when one of your pieces attacks **two enemy pieces at the same time**. The enemy can only save one — so you win the other! Knights are the kings of forking.

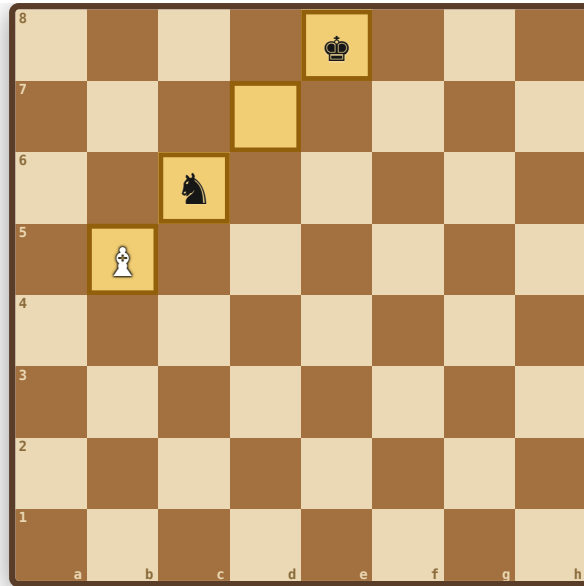


*The white knight on c7 attacks the king AND the rook at once.
The king must move — then the knight grabs the rook!*

✅ A knight that forks the king and queen is so good it has a nickname: the "**royal fork**." Hunt for these!

The Pin — freeze a piece in place 📌

A **pin** is when you attack a piece that can't move out of the way, because something *more* valuable is hiding right behind it. The pinned piece is stuck!



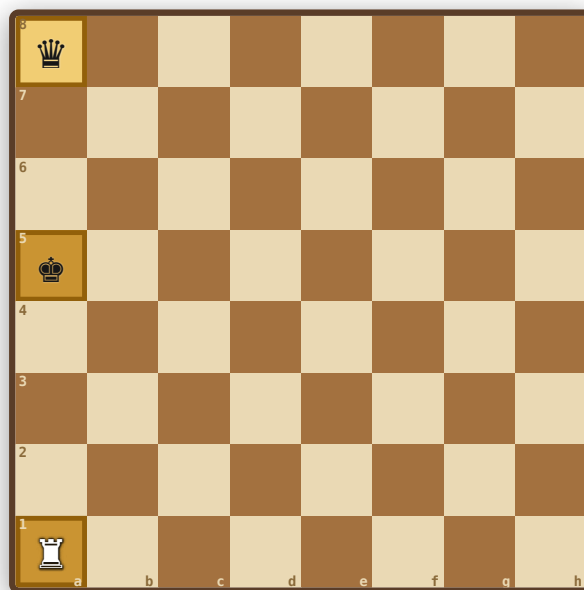
The white bishop pins the black knight to the king. The knight can't move — that would expose the king, which is against the rules!

👑 COACH NOTE

When the piece behind is the **king**, the pinned piece *legally cannot move* (it's an "absolute pin"). When it's just a valuable piece (like a queen) behind, moving is allowed but usually loses material (a "relative pin"). Pins freeze enemy pieces — then you can pile up more attackers and win the frozen piece.

The Skewer — the pin's big brother ✂️

A **skewer** is like a pin flipped around. You attack a *valuable* piece in front; when it moves out of the way to safety, you grab the piece that was hiding behind it.



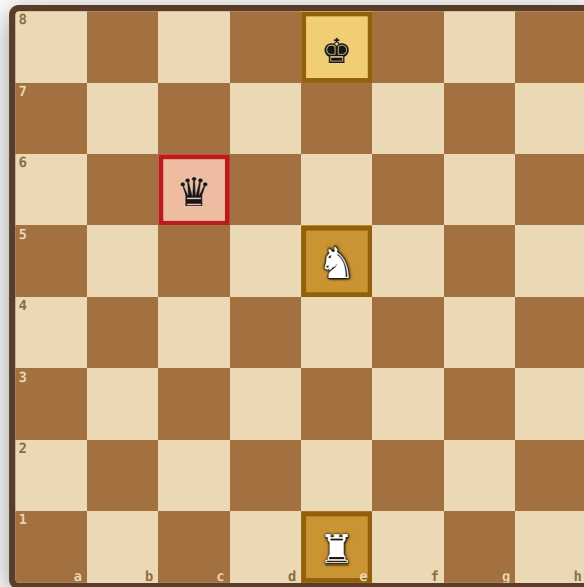
The rook checks the king. The king must step aside — and the rook captures the queen behind it!

★ **Pin vs. Skewer:** In a pin, the *small* piece is in front. In a skewer, the *big* piece is in front and has to move, giving up the piece behind it.

✅ **The golden tactic habit:** every turn, ask "Is anything attacking *me*? Can I attack *two* things at once?" That one question will win you lots of pieces.

The Discovered Attack — the sneaky uncover 🧐

A **discovered attack** happens when you move one piece *out of the way* to uncover an attack from a piece hiding behind it. You make **two** threats with one move — the piece that moved, and the piece it unmasks!

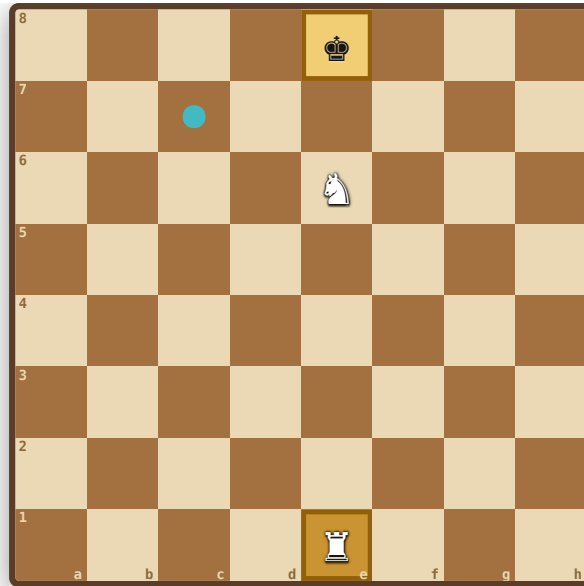


The knight jumps away to grab the queen ([Nxc6](#)) — and uncovers the rook, which now checks the king! Because it's check, black must save the king and can't rescue the queen.

✅ A discovered attack where the uncovered piece gives **check** is the strongest kind — your opponent must answer the check, so your moving piece grabs something for free.

The Double Check — the unstoppable one 💥

Sometimes the moving piece gives check *at the very same time* as the piece it uncovers. That's a **double check** — two pieces checking the king at once. You can't block two checks, and you can't capture two attackers in one move, so the king is **forced** to move.



If the knight jumps to c7, the knight AND the rook both attack the king at once. The only way out is to move the king.

🧠 Double check is so powerful it's the secret behind smothered mate — the king is forced into the corner, then the knight finishes it.

Think Before You Move

The one habit that wins more games than any fancy opening.

The blunder-check routine

The most common way beginners lose isn't a clever trap — it's giving away a piece for free by moving too fast. We call that a **blunder**. The cure is a quick check you do *every single turn*, before you touch a piece.

1 What did my opponent just do?

Did their last move **attack** something of mine, or set up a threat? Don't just answer their move — understand it first.

2 Is anything of mine in danger?

Scan the whole board for your pieces that are attacked and **not protected**. Those are the ones that get lost.

3 Is the move I want to play safe?

Before you let go, ask: "If I move here, can it be captured for free? Am I leaving something else undefended behind it?"

4 Can I do something great?

Now look for *your* chances: a check, a capture that wins material, or a tactic like a fork, pin, or skewer.

Make it a habit

★ **The golden question:** before your hand leaves a piece, ask — "*Is it safe? And what will my opponent do back?*"

⚠ **The #1 beginner blunder:** moving quickly and leaving a piece "hanging" (attacked and undefended). Slowing down for one breath fixes most of your losses.

📖 COACH NOTE

A classic trick to stop impulsive moves is "**sit on your hands**" — literally don't touch a piece until you've finished the four checks above. Even strong players blunder-check on every move; it's not a beginner crutch, it's a lifelong habit. And reviewing your own games afterward to find where you blundered is the single fastest way to improve.

Starting Smart (The Opening)

The first few moves set up your whole game. Here's how to start strong.

The 3 golden opening rules

The beginning of the game is called the **opening**. You don't need to memorize anything fancy — just follow three simple ideas and you'll be ahead of most beginners.

1 Grab the center

Move a center pawn out (like **e4** or **d4**) to claim the middle of the board. The center is like the high ground — your pieces are strongest there.

2 Wake up your pieces (develop!)

Bring your knights and bishops off the back row toward the center. A piece sitting at home is fast asleep — “developing” means putting it to work. Knights usually come out before bishops.

3 Castle to keep your king safe

Once your knight and bishop on the kingside have moved, castle (**0-0**) to tuck your king into the corner. A safe king lets you attack without worry.

Opening "don'ts"

⚠️ **Don't bring your queen out too early.** The enemy's little pieces will chase her around, and you'll waste moves running away.

⚠️ **Don't move the same piece over and over** in the opening. Wake up a *new* piece each turn instead — get your whole army into the game.

⚠️ **Don't grab pawns on the edge** while your king is still in the middle. Safety first!

👑 COACH NOTE

A great first opening to teach is the **Italian Game**: **1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4**. It naturally follows all three rules — center pawn, knight out, bishop aimed at the enemy's weak **f7** square, ready to castle. Simple, classical, and it teaches good habits.

Finishing the Game (The Endgame)

When few pieces are left, here's how to land the win.

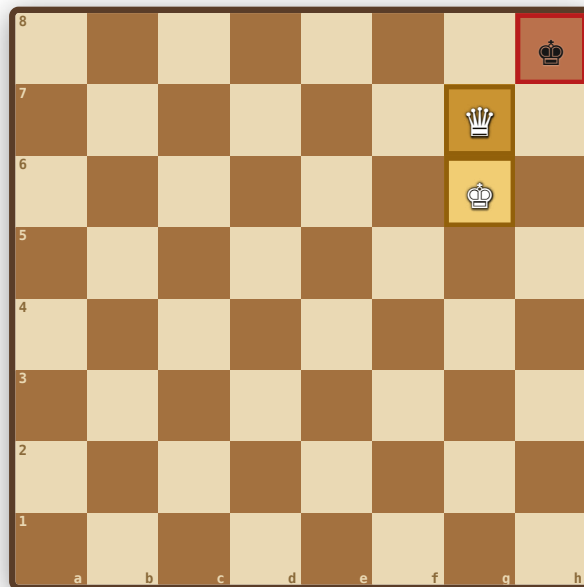
What is the endgame?

The **endgame** is the last part of the game, when most pieces have been traded off and only a few are left. Two big ideas matter most here: **making a new queen** from a pawn, and **checkmating the lonely king**.

✅ In the endgame the king wakes up! With fewer pieces around, it's safe for your king to march into the middle and help fight. A brave endgame king is a strong piece.

The easiest checkmate: King + Queen vs. King

If you have a queen and a king against a lonely king, you can always win. The trick: use your **queen to push** the enemy king toward the edge, and bring your **own king up to help**. The queen alone can't do it — the king must come and help finish!



Checkmate! The queen traps the king on the edge, and the white king guards the queen so she can't be captured.

⚠️ Going for this mate? Watch out for **stalemate**! Don't take away all the king's squares unless it's a real checkmate. Always give him room until the final blow.

👑 COACH NOTE

The method: keep your queen a **knight's-move away** from the enemy king to herd it to the edge without stalemating, then march your own king up so the queen can deliver mate *protected*. The **two-rook "ladder" (or "staircase") mate** is even easier to learn first — the rooks cut off ranks one by one and walk the king off the board, and your own king isn't even needed.

Pawns become queens

In the endgame, an extra pawn is gold. Push it toward the far side, protect it with your king, and turn it into a queen — then use your new queen to checkmate. This is how most simple endgames are won.

★ **Endgame motto:** "Push the pawn, make a queen, then checkmate." If you're ahead, trade pieces (not pawns) to make winning easier.

Your First Whole Game

Let's put it all together — and learn a famous trap to avoid.

A friendly opening, move by move

Here's how a smart, simple game might begin. Try playing these moves on a real board as you read — notice how each one follows our golden rules.

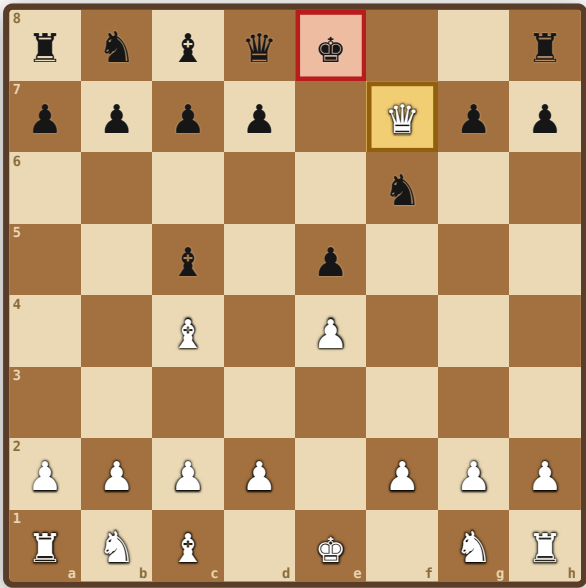
Move	White	Black	The idea
1	e4	e5	Both grab the center with a pawn.
2	Nf3	Nc6	Knights develop and guard pawns.
3	Bc4	Bc5	Bishops come out, aiming at the action.
4	O-O	Nf6	White castles to safety; black develops.

✔ In just four moves, white grabbed the center, woke up two pieces, and tucked the king away safely. That's a textbook start!

⚠ The trap every beginner must know: Scholar's Mate

This is a sneaky 4-move checkmate that catches new players all the time. If you know it, you can **avoid it** — and even use it!

The trick: 1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Bc5 3.Qh5 Nf6?? 4.Qxf7#. The queen and bishop team up to attack the weak f7 square (right next to the king), and... checkmate!



Scholar's Mate. The white queen captures on f7, protected by the bishop on c4. The black king has no escape — checkmate!

How to defend against it

- Watch for the enemy queen and bishop both aiming at your f7 (or f2 for white) square.
- When the queen comes out early to h5, calmly defend: a move like g6 kicks the queen away, or Qe7 guards f7.

- Remember the opening rule: **don't panic, develop, and protect f7!**

 COACH NOTE

The `??` after `Nf6` means "blunder" — it defended the wrong thing. The defense `3...g6!` attacks the queen *and* blocks the path to f7; or `3...Qe7` defends f7 directly. Teaching the Scholar's Mate is wonderful because it shows *why* the opening rules exist — bring the queen out too early and it can backfire badly once your opponent knows the defense.

★ The big lesson: always ask "what is my opponent's piece *threatening?*" before you make your own move.

Keep Getting Better

You know how to play — here's how to grow into a strong player.

Play, play, play!

The number-one way to improve is simply to **play lots of games** — and not be afraid of losing. Every single game teaches you something new.



Play family & friends at home



Join a school or local chess club



Play on a kid-friendly chess app (with a grown-up)



COACH NOTE

Two great kid-safe places to play and learn online are **ChessKid.com** (built just for children, with parent controls) and **Lichess.org** (completely free, no ads). A grown-up should set up and supervise any online account.

The chess clock & time controls

In many games each player has a **chess clock** — a special double timer. When it's your turn, your clock counts down; after you move, you press the button and your opponent's clock starts. If your time runs out, you lose — so the clock keeps games from lasting forever!

Type	Time each player	How it feels
Classical	30+ minutes	Slow and thoughtful
Rapid	about 10–15 min	Quicker, still time to think
Blitz	about 3–5 min	Fast and exciting
Bullet	1–2 min	Super speedy!



While you're learning, play **slow** games (classical or rapid) — you need time to do your blunder-check! Save blitz and bullet for fun once you're comfortable.

Three habits of players who improve

1

Do a puzzle a day

Solving a few tactics puzzles every day trains your eyes to spot forks, pins, and checkmates in your real games. It's the fastest — and funnest — practice there is.

2 Look back at your games

After a game — especially one you lost — go back and find the move where it went wrong. Write your games down (use the scoresheet at the back of this book!) so you can review them later.

3 Learn one new thing at a time

Don't try to learn everything at once. Pick one idea — a checkmate pattern, a tactic, an opening move — and practice it until it feels easy. Then pick the next one.

★ Remember: every grandmaster was once a beginner who lost lots of games. Keep playing, keep learning, and have fun — that's the real secret!

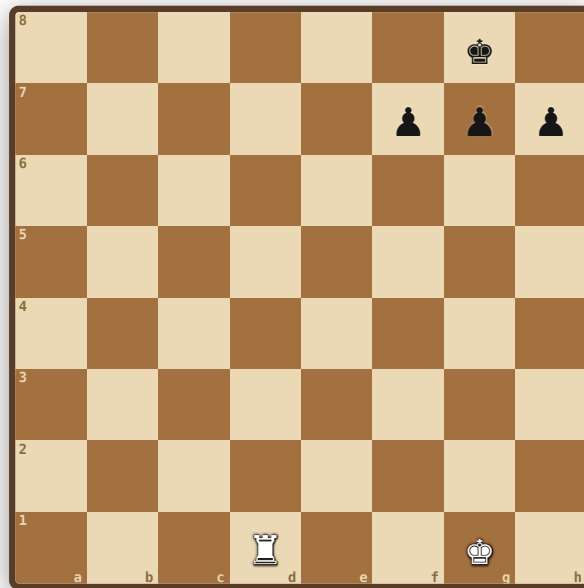
Practice Puzzles

Your turn! Try each one, then tap the button to check your answer.

 **How to solve:** Look at the board, think hard, maybe set it up on a real board. When you have your answer, press the button to see if you're right. No peeking too early — that's where the brain muscles grow!

Puzzle 1 — Checkmate in one move ♔

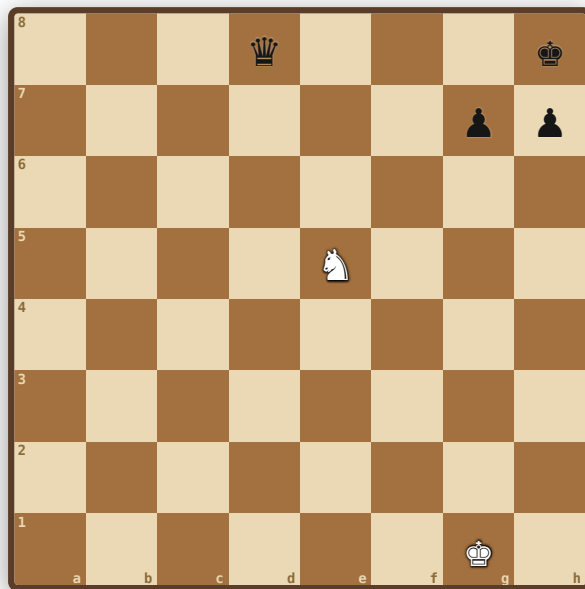
White to move. Can you find a move that checkmates the black king right away?



White has a rook. The black king is hiding behind his pawns...

Puzzle 2 — Win the queen with a fork 🍴

White to move. Your knight can attack the king and the queen at the same time. Where does it jump?



The black king is on **h8** , the queen on **d8** . Find the forking square!

Puzzle 3 — Escape the check 🛡️

Your king is in check. Without looking at any board — can you name the **three different ways** a king can get out of check?

Puzzle 4 — Smart trade or silly trade? 🤔

You can capture the enemy's **knight** with your **queen**. But if you do, their **pawn** will capture your queen right back. Should you do it?

Puzzle 5 — Checkmate or stalemate? 🤔

It's the enemy's turn. Their king is **not in check**, but they have **no legal move** at all. Did you win, or is it a tie?

Good Manners & Habits

A great chess player is also a kind and fair player.

The handshake

Chess players shake hands (or say "good luck!") **before** the game starts and **after** it ends — win or lose. It's a way of saying "thanks for the game, you were a good opponent."

👉 Win politely, lose politely. Saying "good game!" with a smile is the mark of a real champion.

The touch-move rule

This is a real chess rule, and it's also good manners:

- If you touch a piece, you must move it (if it has a legal move).
- If you let go of a piece on a square, your move is finished — no take-backs!
- If you touch an enemy piece, you must capture it (if you legally can).

★ So think first, *then* touch. Plan your move in your head before your fingers reach out.

📚 COACH NOTE

If you only want to *straighten* a piece on its square (not move it), say "**adjust**" (or the French "j'adoube," say "zha-DOOB") *before* you touch it. For very young kids learning at home, it's fine to allow gentle take-backs — but in clubs and tournaments, touch-move is taken seriously.

Being a good sport



Stay calm and quiet while your opponent thinks



Never brag or gloat when you win



Don't sulk when you lose — learn instead!

🎓 **Resigning:** If a position is totally hopeless, older players sometimes "resign" (gently tip over their king) to politely end the game. But when you're learning, it's great to play every game to the very end — you'll learn how to finish, and your opponent might still make a mistake!

✅ **The best habit of all:** every game you lose teaches you something. Champions aren't people who never lose — they're people who learn from losing.

Cheat Sheet

Everything important on one page — come back here any time!

How the pieces move

Piece	Moves	Worth
♙ Pawn	1 forward (2 on first move); captures diagonally; promotes at the end	1
♘ Knight	In an "L" — and can jump over pieces	3
♗ Bishop	Diagonally, any distance (stays on one color)	3
♖ Rook	Straight lines, any distance	5
♕ Queen	Straight AND diagonal, any distance	9
♔ King	One square in any direction	∞

The golden rules



Control the center with your pawns and pieces



Develop your knights and bishops early



Castle to keep your king safe



Check threats — what is the enemy attacking?



Protect before you capture — "can they take back?"



Look for tactics — forks, pins, skewers, discoveries

Notation symbols

Symbol	Meaning
K Q R B N	King, Queen, Rook, Bishop, kNight (pawns have no letter)
x / + / #	capture / check / checkmate
0-0 / 0-0-0	castle kingside / castle queenside
=Q	pawn promotes to a queen

How a game can end

You win 🏆

Checkmate — the enemy king is in check and can't escape. Also, the enemy may **resign**.

It's a tie 🤝

Draw — stalemate, agreement, repetition, the 50-move rule, or too few pieces to mate.

Glossary A–Z

All the chess words in this guide, explained simply.

Chess words, A to Z

Word	What it means
Bishop	A piece that slides diagonally and stays on one color all game. Worth 3.
Blunder	A bad move that gives away a piece or the game — usually from moving too fast. Blunder-check every turn!
Capture	Taking an enemy piece off the board by moving onto its square.
Castling	A special move where the king and a rook move at once, to keep the king safe.
Check	When the king is being attacked. You must get out of it immediately.
Checkmate	Check with no escape. The game is over — and you win!
Develop	Bringing your pieces out from the back row to do their jobs.
Diagonal	A slanted line of same-colored squares, corner to corner.
Discovered attack	Moving one piece to uncover an attack from a piece hiding behind it — two threats in one move.
Double check	Two pieces checking the king at once. It can't be blocked or captured away — the king must move.
Draw	A tied game — nobody wins.
En passant	A special pawn capture against a pawn that just made its two-square sprint.
Endgame	The last part of the game, with only a few pieces left.
File	A column of squares going up and down, named a – h .
Fork	One piece attacking two enemy pieces at the same time.
King	The most important piece. Moves one square. Must never be captured.
Knight	The horse that jumps in an "L" shape and hops over pieces. Worth 3.
Material	Your pieces and their total point value. "Up material" means you have more.
Notation	The written code for chess moves, like Nf3 or e4 .
Opening	The first part of the game, when you set up your army.
Pawn	The little soldier. Moves forward, captures diagonally, can promote. Worth 1.
Pin	Freezing a piece because something more valuable hides behind it.
Promotion	When a pawn reaches the far end and turns into a queen (usually).
Queen	The strongest piece — moves like a rook and bishop combined. Worth 9.

Rank	A row of squares going left to right, named 1 – 8 .
Resign	Politely giving up a hopeless game by tipping over your king.
Rook	The castle tower. Moves in straight lines. Worth 5.
Skewer	Attacking a valuable piece in front so it moves, letting you grab the one behind.
Smothered mate	A knight checkmate of a king that is trapped by its own pieces.
Stalemate	No check, but no legal move — the game is a draw.
Tactic	A short clever trick that wins pieces or checkmates.
Touch-move	The rule that if you touch a piece, you must move it.

You did it — you've learned chess! Now go play. ♟️♚♙♜♞♛

Puzzle Answer Key

No peeking until you've tried each one! Solutions to the Practice Puzzles.

Puzzle 1 — Checkmate in one move

Rd8# — the rook slides to **d8** and checks along the back row. The king can't escape because his own pawns block the only exits. A classic **back-rank mate**!

Puzzle 2 — Win the queen with a fork

Nf7+ — the knight jumps to **f7**, checking the king AND attacking the queen. After the king moves out of check, **Nxd8** captures the queen. A royal fork!

Puzzle 3 — Escape the check

The three ways: **1. Move** the king to a safe square. **2. Block** the check with another piece. **3. Capture** the attacker. If none of the three is possible, it's checkmate!

Puzzle 4 — Smart trade or silly trade?

No way! Giving up your queen (9) to win just a knight (3) loses 6 points — a terrible trade. Always ask "can they take me back?" before you capture.

Puzzle 5 — Checkmate or stalemate?

It's a **tie (stalemate)**, not a win! Checkmate needs the king to be *in check* with no escape. No check + no legal move = stalemate = draw.

My Progress Checklist

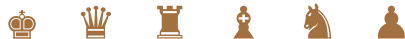
Tick each box when you can do it without any help!

- ☐ I can set up the board the right way (light square on the right)
- ☐ I know how the pawn, rook, bishop, knight, queen, and king all move
- ☐ I can capture pieces correctly — including the pawn's diagonal capture
- ☐ I know what *check* means and the three ways to escape it
- ☐ I can deliver a checkmate
- ☐ I know the difference between checkmate and stalemate
- ☐ I can castle, promote a pawn, and capture en passant
- ☐ I can read and write moves in notation (like `e4` and `Nf3`)
- ☐ I know how many points each piece is worth
- ☐ I can spot a fork, a pin, and a skewer
- ☐ I do a blunder-check before every move
- ☐ I can checkmate a lonely king with two rooks (the ladder)
- ☐ I know the three opening rules: center, develop, castle
- ☐ I have played a whole game from start to finish
- ☐ I shook hands and was a good sport

My Games

Write down your moves as you play, then look back at them later. Example: 1. e4 e5

#	White	Black	#	White	Black
1			21		
2			22		
3			23		
4			24		
5			25		
6			26		
7			27		
8			28		
9			29		
10			30		
11			31		
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15			35		
16			36		
17			37		
18			38		
19			39		
20			40		



Chess Champion

This certificate proudly says that

has learned how to play chess — setting up the board,
moving every piece, and delivering checkmate!

Date

Coach / Grown-up